HR-204 Flexible Working

Policy ID: HR-204 Version: 3.2 Classification: Internal
Effective Date: 1 January 2026 Owner: People Operations
Applies to: All employees with twenty-six weeks of continuous service

1 Purpose and Scope

This policy explains what flexible working means, who may apply, and how to make a request. It covers permanent changes to the contract of employment as well as informal and temporary arrangements.

A flexible working request is a request to change the terms on which work is done. It is not a request to work less, and it is not a benefit granted by seniority.

2 Forms of Flexible Work

Flexible working includes a change to the hours worked, the times at which they are worked, the days on which they are worked, or the place from which they are worked.

Common forms are part-time working, compressed hours, flexible start and finish times, job sharing, term-time working, and a permanent change to the proportion of time worked remotely.

Day-to-day variation in start and finish times within the limits in HR-201 section 2.1 is not a flexible working request and needs no application.

3 Eligibility

Any employee with at least twenty-six weeks of continuous service may make a formal flexible working request. Service is counted from the start date recorded in the human resources system.

An employee may make two formal requests in any twelve-month period. The twelve months run from the date of the first request, not from its outcome.

Employees with less than twenty-six weeks of service may ask for an informal arrangement under section 4.1.

4 Making a Request

4.1 Informal Arrangements

Where an employee needs a short-term or occasional adjustment, they should discuss it with their manager directly. Informal arrangements do not change the contract of employment and may be ended by either party with reasonable notice.

A manager who agrees an informal arrangement expected to last more than eight weeks should record it in writing, so that both parties know what was agreed and when it ends.

An informal arrangement that has run for more than six months should be converted into a formal request, so that the employee has the protection of a contractual change.

4.2 Requesting a Flexible Working Arrangement

A formal request is made in writing through the human resources system. It must state the change sought, the date on which it should take effect, the effect the employee thinks it will have on the team, and how that effect might be managed.

The manager holds a meeting with the employee within twenty-eight calendar days of receiving the request. The employee may be accompanied by a colleague.

The manager gives a decision in writing within fourteen calendar days of the meeting. The whole process must be completed within two months of the request, including any appeal.

5 Declining a Request

A request may be declined only for one of the following reasons: the burden of additional cost; a detrimental effect on the ability to meet customer demand; an inability to reorganise work among existing staff; an inability to recruit additional staff; a detrimental impact on quality or performance; insufficiency of work during the periods the employee proposes to work; or a planned structural change.

A decision to decline must state which reason applies and explain how it applies to this request. A decision that names a reason without explaining it is not a valid decision.

Where a request is declined, the manager should consider whether a modified version of the arrangement could work, and record that consideration.

6 Trial Periods

A manager may approve a request on a trial basis for a defined period, normally three months. The trial period and the criteria for assessing it are agreed in writing before the trial begins.

At the end of the trial, the arrangement is either confirmed as a permanent change to the contract or ended, and the reason is recorded. A trial that is neither confirmed nor ended becomes permanent after six months.

7 Appeals

An employee whose request is declined may appeal in writing within fourteen calendar days of the decision. The appeal is heard by someone not involved in the original decision, within fourteen calendar days of being received.

8 Related Policies

Remote and hybrid working is covered by HR-206. Working hours are covered by HR-201.

Requests connected to a disability, to caring responsibilities covered by statute, or to a return from parental leave are handled outside this policy and must be directed to an HR business partner.

9 Records

Flexible working requests and their outcomes are retained for three years from the date of the decision.

10 Review

This policy is reviewed every two years, or earlier where legislation changes.